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FREE GUIDE

East Valley Neighborhood Spotlights

An insider's look at the East Valley, with 15 San Tan Valley and Florence neighborhoods in detail.

Homes, schools, daily life, and the tradeoffs. I specialize in San Tan Valley & Florence.

About This Guide

San Tan Valley and Florence are my specialty. They're where I live and know the streets best, so those get the most detail here. I also help buyers and sellers throughout the greater Phoenix area and across Arizona, not only in these areas. Each San Tan Valley and Florence neighborhood below is summarized from my full neighborhood guides at thebutlerrealty.com/neighborhoods, where you'll find schools, getting around, and the tradeoffs to know about each one. Other East Valley cities follow at the end.

About prices: Prices move with the market, so this guide doesn't print a number that would be out of date next month. Call or text me and I'll send you what has actually closed in the area or neighborhood you're considering over the last 90 days. For monthly numbers for San Tan Valley and Florence, download my free market report at thebutlerrealty.com/resources.

San Tan Valley

San Tan Valley sits south of Queen Creek and north of Florence, against the San Tan Mountains. For years people described it as the unincorporated part of Pinal County south of Queen Creek. That description is out of date.

Residents voted to incorporate on August 5, 2025. Pinal County approved the incorporation on September 17, 2025, and the new Town of San Tan Valley took over services that the county used to run on July 1, 2026. It is Arizona's 92nd municipality and, with more than 100,000 residents, the largest community ever to incorporate in the state. Town hall is at the San Tan Valley County Complex on Schnepf Road, and town services are still being built out. When you buy here, ask who currently provides the service at that address today, not who provided it two years ago.

Johnson Ranch

Johnson Ranch is the community most people picture first when they say San Tan Valley. It is a roughly 2,000-acre master plan at Hunt Highway and Bella Vista Road, built out from the early 2000s, with an 18-hole public golf course running through it, three recreation centers, and commercial corners at Hunt Highway and Bella Vista so groceries and coffee do not require a trip to Queen Creek.

Good fit

Buyers who want amenities, golf, and services inside the neighborhood and who plan to use them; buyers who want middle and high school in the Florence Unified system nearby; sellers in the earlier villages who price against condition honestly.

Look elsewhere if

You do not want an HOA at all (look at ranchette pockets), or you need the shortest possible commute to the 202 and price is secondary (start in Ironwood Crossing or Pecan Creek), or you want a gated 55-plus setup (look at Solera, inside this same master plan).

Solera at Johnson Ranch (55-plus)

Solera is the gated 55-plus Del Webb enclave inside the much larger, all-ages Johnson Ranch master plan. You get two layers: a private Solera clubhouse and pool for Solera residents, and access to the wider Johnson Ranch amenities and the 18-hole golf course that runs through the neighborhood. For a lot of buyers that is the right compromise — a quieter, age-restricted street to come home to, without being cut off from grandkids, golf, and the recreation centers down the road.

Good fit

Buyers 55-plus who want single-level living, a real clubhouse social calendar, and golf in the neighborhood, at a San Tan Valley price point; seasonal residents who want a gated, low-maintenance home to lock and leave (confirm the association's exterior maintenance scope).

Look elsewhere if

You want a brand-new 55-plus build with a large resort club (look at Trilogy at Encanterra or Sun City Anthem at Merrill Ranch in Florence), or you do not want two HOA layers, or nobody in the household meets the age restriction rules. At least one occupant must be 55-plus and there are limits on occupants under 19 — get the current rules from the association, in writing, before you write.

Encanterra

Encanterra is the resort end of San Tan Valley. It is a gated Shea Homes community built around the La Casa club — close to 60,000 square feet of dining, pools, spa, fitness and event space — a second smaller club called The Algarve, and a private Tom Lehman-designed golf course. Part of the community is open to all ages and part is Trilogy, the 55-plus section. Everyone uses the same clubs.

Good fit

Buyers who want a private club life — golf, spa, dining, clubs and classes — without driving to Scottsdale to get it; 55-plus buyers who want a newer home and a large clubhouse; all-ages buyers who want a gated community with that same amenity base.

Look elsewhere if

Club dues on top of an HOA do not fit the monthly budget you want to carry; you want no HOA or a rural lot; or you will not use the amenities. Paying for La Casa and never walking into it is the most common way buyers overspend in San Tan Valley.

Pecan Creek (North and South)

Pecan Creek is where a lot of Queen Creek overflow landed, and it still works that way. It sits in the northern part of San Tan Valley, south of Ocotillo Road around Ironwood/Gantzel, split into Pecan Creek North and Pecan Creek South, with about 1,300 homes between them. The draw is straightforward: elementary schools inside the neighborhood, four main parks connected by walking paths, and a shorter drive to Queen Creek retail and the Loop 202 than most of San Tan Valley gets.

Good fit

Buyers who want an elementary school they can walk to and a shorter Queen Creek commute; buyers who would rather have a larger floor plan than a community pool; sellers with an updated home, because original-condition competition is common here.

Look elsewhere if

A community pool and clubhouse are must-haves (Ironwood Crossing, Johnson Ranch), or you want Florence Unified schools specifically, or you want a brand-new build (look at the active new construction around the valley and in Florence).

Copper Basin

Copper Basin was designed differently than most of San Tan Valley. Instead of a subdivision with a park in the middle, it was built around a village center on Main Street: a YMCA, an elementary school, a fire station, and a 20-acre park, all inside the neighborhood. About 847 acres off Hunt Highway and Copper Mine Road. That layout changes the daily routine. A lot of the week can happen without getting on Hunt Highway.

Good fit

Buyers who want the school, the Y, and the park inside the neighborhood; buyers who want a newer phase without going all the way to a brand-new Florence subdivision; sellers in the older villages who have done the kitchen and systems work buyers are screening for.

Look elsewhere if

You want no HOA, or a private-club amenity level (Encanterra), or the shortest commute north (Ironwood Crossing, Pecan Creek).

Ironwood Crossing

Ironwood Crossing is the amenity-heavy option in northern San Tan Valley. Built by Fulton Homes at Ironwood and Ocotillo, it has about 20 parks, an aquatics center with a splash pad and a heated pool of roughly 7,000 square feet that is open year-round, a clubhouse, and a charter school campus inside the community. It also has one of the better commute positions in the valley, up Ironwood to the Loop 202 and State Route 24.

Good fit

Buyers who will use a community pool and aquatics center weekly in summer and do not want to maintain a private pool; buyers who want a charter school option inside the neighborhood; sellers with a renovated home, because you are competing with a lot of original-condition listings.

Look elsewhere if

The HOA amount bothers you more than the amenities are worth to you (Pecan Creek), or you want Florence Unified schools (most of southern San Tan Valley), or you want an acre lot with no HOA.

Circle Cross Ranch

Circle Cross Ranch is a Pulte-built master community off Gantzel (Ironwood) and Empire Boulevard in the northern-central part of San Tan Valley. It has its own elementary school, a large central park — Empire Park — and a trail system that runs through the neighborhood. Of the Florence Unified communities in San Tan Valley, it is one of the closer ones to Queen Creek, Gilbert, and Mesa, which is why it lands on a lot of short lists for people who work north but want Florence Unified schools or a southern San Tan Valley price.

Good fit

Buyers in the Florence Unified area who want the elementary school in the neighborhood and a shorter northern commute than the rest of Florence Unified San Tan Valley; buyers who prefer a built-out, established neighborhood over a construction zone; sellers who have maintained systems, because buyers here are comparing condition closely.

Look elsewhere if

You want a brand-new home (Florence new construction, or the active building elsewhere in the valley), a community pool and clubhouse (Ironwood Crossing, Johnson Ranch), or no HOA.

San Tan Heights

San Tan Heights is one of the largest communities in San Tan Valley, roughly 3,800 homes built into the foothills on the west side of the valley, with the San Tan Mountains in front of you and the Superstitions behind. People buy here for the views, the trails, and the space between houses compared to the tighter northern subdivisions. They accept a longer drive to do it.

Good fit

Buyers who put mountain views and trail access ahead of commute minutes; buyers in the Florence Unified area; buyers who want a larger community with a range of home sizes, including smaller lower-maintenance options.

Look elsewhere if

Daily freeway commute time is your top priority (Pecan Creek, Ironwood Crossing), or you want a community pool and clubhouse as the center of the neighborhood (Johnson Ranch, Ironwood Crossing).

Skyline Ranch

Skyline Ranch sits at the base of the San Tan Mountains on the west side of San Tan Valley, along Hunt Highway near Gary Road. It is a quieter, more open-feeling community than the northern subdivisions: earth-toned Mediterranean-style homes on sidewalk-lined streets, desert landscaping, and mountain views that you do not have to buy a premium lot to get. At the edge of it is Encanto Real, a gated enclave of custom homes on acre lots with horse privileges, which is a different purchase entirely and is covered separately below.

Good fit

Buyers who prioritize mountain views and trail access; buyers who want more house for the money than the northern valley offers and can absorb the drive; acre-lot and horse buyers in Encanto Real; sellers on view lots, because that premium is real and needs to be marketed to the right buyer pool.

Look elsewhere if

Commute minutes are the top priority, you want a clubhouse pool community, or you need walkable retail.

Rancho Bella Vista (North and South)

Rancho Bella Vista is really two communities built in the 2000s in southern San Tan Valley. The original Rancho Bella Vista is at Hunt Highway and Bella Vista Road, about 936 homes started in 2003. Rancho Bella Vista South is at Gantzel and Bella Vista, about 591 homes built 2005–2009. Between them you are looking at roughly 1,500 homes of established, resale housing with farmland around the edges and mountain views that the newer, tighter subdivisions do not always get.

Good fit

Buyers who want an established home with a lighter HOA profile and do not need a community pool; buyers who work in or near Florence or Coolidge; sellers who have done the systems work and want it credited in the price.

Look elsewhere if

A community pool, clubhouse, or YMCA is a must-have (Copper Basin, Johnson Ranch, Ironwood Crossing), or you want a new build with a warranty (Florence new construction).

Florence

Florence is the Pinal County seat, southeast of San Tan Valley on State Route 79, and it is really three different real estate markets sharing a name.

The first is historic Florence: the original town along Main Street, with adobe and territorial-era buildings, the 1891 Pinal County Courthouse, McFarland State Historic Park, and homes that range from historic properties to small established subdivisions and manufactured housing.

Historic Downtown Florence

Downtown Florence is the original town, and it does not look or live like the subdivisions north of it. Main Street runs past the second Pinal County Courthouse from 1891, McFarland State Historic Park in the first courthouse from 1878, the Florence Community Library, town hall, and a small set of local restaurants and shops. Around it are the town's oldest neighborhoods: historic adobe and territorial-era homes in and near the historic district, post-war and later homes in the original town subdivisions, and — a few streets away — established manufactured home areas including Florence Gardens.

Good fit

Buyers who want character, history, and a walkable town core; buyers priced out of the master plans who would rather put money into an older home they can improve over time; county and town employees who want a short commute; sellers of well-kept in-town homes, because renovated historic and in-town homes are scarce compared to subdivision resales.

Look elsewhere if

You want new construction and a warranty (the corridor west and north of town), a clubhouse and golf lifestyle (Merrill Ranch), or strict HOA-maintained uniformity on every street.

Anthem at Merrill Ranch — Parkside (All Ages)

Merrill Ranch is the master plan that put modern Florence on the map for most buyers. It sits on the north side of Florence along Hunt Highway, and it is split in two: Sun City Anthem, the 55-plus section to the north, and Parkside, the all-ages section to the south. Parkside wraps around a large community park with sports fields, a fishing pond, a dog park, a splash pad and playgrounds, with the Poston Butte Golf Club running through the community and Florence Hospital at the northeast edge.

Good fit

Buyers who want a master plan park and pool without leaving Florence; buyers who value the golf course and the community calendar; sellers who present total cost honestly and have the condition to compete with new series nearby.

Look elsewhere if

The CFD plus HOA total does not fit your budget (look at the newer non-CFD subdivisions, or at Florence Gardens for 55-plus); you want to be in the historic town itself; or you need a fast freeway commute (start in San Tan Valley).

Sun City Anthem at Merrill Ranch (55-plus)

Sun City Anthem is the 55-plus northern section of the Merrill Ranch master plan in Florence. It has its own large private clubhouse for Sun City residents, and it also sits inside the larger Merrill Ranch community, so residents use the master plan's park, lakes, sports courts and water amenities as well. The Poston Butte Golf Club winds through the community. For 55-plus buyers who want a big-clubhouse lifestyle at a Florence price instead of a Queen Creek or Mesa price, this is usually the first community to look at in this part of Pinal County.

Good fit

55-plus buyers who want a large clubhouse and a full social calendar, golf in the community, and a single-level home; buyers relocating to be near San Tan Valley or Queen Creek who want their own 55-plus base 20 minutes away instead of in the same subdivision.

Look elsewhere if

Total carrying cost with CFD and HOA does not fit; you want a brand-new 55-plus build (Trilogy at Encanterra, with a different dues structure); or you want to be inside the East Valley for daily errands and medical appointments (Solera at Johnson Ranch shortens that drive).

Magma Ranch and the New Construction Corridor

Most of the Florence home search in 2026 runs through new construction, and most of it sits west and northwest of historic Florence: Magma Ranch and its newer Magma Ranch Vistas series near San Tan Valley, Magic Ranch (including Oasis at Magic Ranch), and a set of active builder subdivisions along Arizona Farms Road and the Hunt Highway corridor. D.R. Horton, Starlight Homes, Meritage, Pulte, LGI, and Century Communities have all been active in Florence in recent series.

Good fit

First-time and move-up buyers who want a new home and a warranty at a Florence price point; buyers who qualify well and can use a builder rate buydown effectively; VA and FHA buyers, who are a large part of this corridor's market and should have the incentive sheet priced into the comparison from the start.

Look elsewhere if

You want an established neighborhood with mature landscaping and no construction (Merrill Ranch resales, Rancho Bella Vista in San Tan Valley); you want land and no HOA; or build timing and phase uncertainty do not fit your move date.

Florence Gardens (55-plus)

Florence Gardens is the value end of 55-plus living in Florence, and the reason is in one sentence: you own the land. This is an established 55-plus community of ground-set manufactured homes on about 1,219 privately owned lots. There is no lot rent. There is a homeowner association with a comparatively low annual fee, a clubhouse, pools, and a full activity calendar. For buyers 55 and older who want to own their lot, keep monthly costs down, and still have people and things to do, Florence Gardens has been the answer in Florence for a long time.

Good fit

55-plus buyers who want to own their land, keep monthly costs low, and have an active clubhouse life without master plan dues; cash and well-prepared buyers who understand manufactured home financing before they shop; sellers who price inside the community's own sold data and have their title and foundation paperwork in order.

Look elsewhere if

You need conventional site-built construction for your loan program or your own comfort (Sun City Anthem), you want a new build with a warranty, or you are not willing to do the extra lending and insurance diligence that a manufactured home requires.

Elsewhere in the East Valley

Here's a quick look at five other East Valley cities. Wherever you're looking, in these cities or anywhere else in Arizona, I'm glad to help. Tell me what matters to you and I'll help you compare areas.

Gilbert

Gilbert grew from a farming town into one of the East Valley's larger cities. Its Heritage District is a walkable downtown area with restaurants, bars, and shops, and its park system includes Freestone Park and the Riparian Preserve at Water Ranch, a popular spot for walking trails and bird watching. Community events include Gilbert Days and seasonal festivals.

Parts of Gilbert are served by Gilbert Public Schools, Higley Unified, and Chandler Unified, so verify the assigned schools by address.

Mesa

Mesa is the East Valley's largest city, with a wide range of home ages and styles, from established neighborhoods near downtown to newer master-planned communities in the southeast. Downtown Mesa has an arts district with museums and galleries, Mesa Riverview is a shopping and entertainment district, Sloan Park hosts Cactus League spring training, and Usery Mountain Regional Park offers hiking and mountain biking. Light rail runs through west Mesa into Tempe and Phoenix.

Mesa Unified is the largest district; Gilbert and Queen Creek districts serve parts of east Mesa. Verify the assigned schools by address. With older homes anywhere, a thorough inspection of systems such as HVAC, roofing, and plumbing is worth planning for.

Chandler

Chandler has a major technology and finance employment base and a walkable downtown with restaurants, boutiques, and entertainment venues. Tumbleweed Park and Veterans Oasis Park provide outdoor recreation, Chandler Fashion Center anchors the shopping, and annual events include the Ostrich Festival, the Chandler Jazz Festival, and the Tumbleweed Tree Lighting.

Most of Chandler is served by Chandler Unified School District. Verify the assigned schools by address.

Queen Creek

Queen Creek has grown from a farming community into a major new-construction market while keeping its agricultural roots. The Queen Creek Olive Mill, Schnepf Farms, pumpkin patches, and u-pick orchards give it a character you won't find elsewhere in the East Valley, and the town has trail systems and mountain access.

Queen Creek Unified serves most of the town, and Higley Unified serves some western areas. Verify the assigned schools by address.

Apache Junction

Apache Junction sits at the base of the Superstition Mountains. Lost Dutchman State Park offers hiking, the Apache Trail Scenic Drive is one of Arizona's best-known drives, and Canyon Lake and nearby Saguaro Lake offer boating and fishing. Retail is concentrated along the US-60 corridor, and housing includes a mix of site-built and manufactured homes.

Apache Junction Unified School District serves the area. Verify the assigned schools by address.

Not Sure Which Area Is Right for You?

That's what I'm here for. Tell me what matters most (schools, commute, space, amenities, budget) and I'll help you narrow it down. Sometimes the right neighborhood isn't the one you expected.

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